

Stretching before you've even started moving

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 1 myth · 8 sources · cheatgrid.com

Holding a stretch before you run or lift doesn't lower your odds of getting hurt, and held too long, it can leave you **a touch weaker** right when you need the strength.

THE GOAL

You're not trying to tick off a ritual. You spend those first minutes moving the way you're about to move, building up gradually, so you're ready when the real effort starts.

CHECKLIST

About to run or lift, and about to reach for the stretch you always hold first

- ☐ Start with two or three minutes of easy movement, like a slow jog or an empty-bar set, instead of **a long standing hold**.
- ☐ Move each joint you're about to load through its own range a few times: leg swings, arm circles, a few bodyweight squats.
- ☐ Match the movement to what's coming: easy strides before a sprint set, the same lift at an empty bar before you add plates.
- ☐ If a spot feels tighter than the rest, take it through its own range a few times rather than holding it stretched.
- ☐ If it's early, cold, or you feel stiffer than usual today, spend longer on the easy movement before you pick up the pace.
- ☐ Build the pace or the load up gradually instead of going full effort on your very first rep.
- ☐ Check the weight on the bar or the ground under you matches what you expect, right before your first full-effort rep.
- ☐ If you still want to hold a stretch, **keep each one under a minute per muscle**.
- ☐ Save a longer, deeper hold for once you're done, not before you start.
- ☐ If you're short on time, do the lighter version of what's coming for a minute rather than cut this step.
- ☐ Pick two or three movements you'll reuse before every session, so this doesn't take planning each time.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 A stretch **costs you most on a fixed, all-out push, not a moving lift**, and least on fast, springy moves.
- 2 A held stretch on its own falls short as a real warm-up before a strength or power session.
- 3 Movement experts, coaches, and physios tested on the evidence got **more than half of it wrong** too.

What the held stretch does to what's coming

DO

Holding a stretch can feel like the responsible move. In these pooled trials, moving first made people's sprint time faster, while holding a stretch first made it slightly slower.

Moving into the coming motion first made people's sprint faster in these pooled trials, while holding a stretch made it slower. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

A stretch **costs you most on a fixed, all-out push, not a moving lift**, and least on fast, springy moves.

People holding a fixed maximal effort lost more strength from the stretch than people doing fast, springy moves. [Source 2](#)

DO A held stretch on its own falls short as a real warm-up before a strength or power session.

A stretch alone still cost people a little strength, even though it barely touched their power. [Source 2](#)

RULE A short stretch, under about a minute per muscle, barely costs you strength or power. Longer holds **cost real ground**.

Keeping a stretch under a minute barely cost people any strength or power, while holding longer cost noticeably more. [Source 3](#)

What actually gets you ready to move

DO Warming up with real movement, not just a stretch, reliably helps: a pooled review found it improved performance on about eight out of ten of the measures tested.

Real movement in the warm-up, not stretching alone, improved most of what these studies measured. [Source 4](#)

KNOW A muscle warms up and gets ready to work through movement.

Most of what a warm-up does for you comes from a rise in muscle temperature, which **active movement** produces. [Source 5](#)

Why this doesn't carry over, and why you weren't taught wrong on purpose

KNOW A single stretch does ease you up a little right now: it lowers muscle stiffness immediately. The real gain in how far you can push into a stretch only builds up over repeated sessions.

A single session eased muscle stiffness right away, but only repeated sessions let people comfortably stretch further. [Source 6](#)

KNOW Movement experts, coaches, and physios tested on the evidence got **more than half of it wrong** too.

Exercise and health professionals surveyed on the evidence matched it on only 10 of the 22 questions asked. [Source 7](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH A stretch before your workout keeps you from getting hurt.

ACTUALLY Across the pooled controlled studies, stretching beforehand made **no real difference** to how many people got hurt, in either direction. [Source 8](#)

Sources

1. https://www.ebi.ac.uk/europepmc/webservices/rest/search?query=EXT_ID:37644585&format=json&resultType=core
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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Warming up, stretching and soreness at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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